

****The Morality of the Pagan Hero****

****JULIUS CAESAR*****

But [Caesar's] great prosperitie and good fortune that favored him all his life time, did continue afterwards in the revenge of his death, pursuing the murtherers both by sea and land, till they had not left a man more to be executed, of all them that were actors or counsellors in the conspiracy of his death.¹

Julius Caesar is the story of a man who became a god. Beyond his merely human achievements—the destruction of the Republic and the establishment of a universal monarchy—he was worshiped as a divinity, as were many of those who inherited his name. His appearance ended forever the age of human heroes. Caesar brought to fulfillment the end implied in all heroic ambition; he proved himself the best of all men. He had no competitor; he was benefactor without being beneficiary. Finally, his spirit ruled Rome, conveyed the sole title to legitimacy, and punished all offenders against it. He was, in short, self-sufficient.

Shakespeare analyzes this greatest of political accomplishments—the enormity of the talent required to compass it and the ambiguity of its worth once brought into being. We never see this prodigy in action; we see him speak, and we see the shadow he casts over the world so that men act only in relation to him and the very heavens seem to reflect his image. A study of the lesser figures who surrounded Caesar is the only way to an understanding of the elements which made him what he was and enabled him to do what he did. And their presentation is so complex that, for many, it is even unclear whether the hero is Caesar or Brutus. But, whatever one's conclusion on that, no one can deny that Caesar or what he represents dominates everyone in the play and that we must begin by looking at Caesar and his Rome.

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Goethe² to the contrary, Shakespeare's Romans are not Englishmen, but real Romans, a distinct kind of men, differing from modern men in the character of their passions and their goals. He cloaked them in a garb recognizable to his audience; otherwise they would not have listened. But the essential diversity emerges. This is not to say that modernity or the fall of antiquity have changed human nature, but rather that new objects have been provided for its interest and that a new education forms it. It is precisely because human nature has not changed that the past is of interest. What men once were, we can still be.

The Romans were the products of other laws and a different understanding of the first things. Shakespeare made an effort to reproduce them so that we could grasp something of the meaning and worth of their institutions and beliefs. His endeavor is one of the most difficult a historian or playwright can undertake; he must convey a plausible picture to an audience which is alien to the character and goals of his subjects and even unaware of its ignorance of them. He himself must understand those subjects, who are so distant from any original experience he could have. The rediscovery of the atmosphere of ancient Rome is akin to the rediscovery, made in the Renaissance, of the beauty of classical sculpture. That art depicted men of a grace and nobility quite alien to what Europeans had grown accustomed to. It was attractive and enigmatic; it seemed to offer an alternative notion of

humanity. But to understand that alternative required an intense effort of sympathy and scholarship, for men were no longer aware of what the ancients saw in the world or of the passions which moved them. It is no easy thing to capture an awareness of what one is not.

This undertaking was, in a sense, what we call the Renaissance. Along with the art of antiquity, the political life of ancient Rome began to attract interest and admiration. Rome had not been utterly forgotten, but it had been seen through the perspective of the Church Fathers' polemics against it; Rome had become part of a particular tradition. It had to be recovered from under the layers of prejudice, and the magnitude of this accomplishment can be felt if one compares Augustine's Rome to Machiavelli's. But it was a quest enlivened by expectation of the discovery of a new world.

Shakespeare is a product and fulfillment of this movement of rediscovery. His Roman plays present us with the essential Rome, and in them he tried to re-create those elusive qualities that made the Romans what they were. Rome, however, no longer interests modern men as it did all but our most recent predecessors, perhaps because we no longer need its example or possibly because we have forgotten what it was. It is well, therefore, to remind ourselves what Rome must have meant to at least the educated among Shakespeare's audience, for this consciousness is what he could count on in developing the stories of his heroes.

In Shakespeare's day, the remnants of the Roman Empire were still alive, and it was still remembered that Britain itself had been a part of it. There were still Caesars ruling, as was the case until World War I. The only nations that were graced with the adjective "civilized" were within the confines of that empire. The principles of law were either Roman or derived from Roman law. Liberal education was largely education in the Roman tongue; the philosophy and poetry that were the permanent standards of excellence were Roman or had been transmitted by the Romans. More important, the models of political greatness, either for individuals or nations, were Roman.

Whether for good or ill, the Roman achievement was so stunning that it could not fail to impress men who were interested in establishing respectable political orders. This single city had conquered the world and produced a multitude of heroes in every age until the fall of the Republic. This merely external side of Rome is played on by Shakespeare in both **Julius Caesar** and **Antony and Cleopatra**. One is constantly aware that the stake in the struggle for domination is the whole world. The problems of the heroes take on commensurate proportions, and so do their talents. The wishes and dreams of every public or private man find an extreme satisfaction in the very contemplation of this spectacle and the opportunity for fantasy which it affords.

It is against this background that the Roman plays must be seen. Rome is, in a way, everything—the source and the end. Whatever Shakespeare's final judgment of Rome may have been or however great the potential superiority of England may have appeared to him, Rome possesses, in his treatment of it, an incomparable splendor and grandeur. The Romans were the greatest political people who ever existed. They differed greatly from Elizabethan Englishmen. It would be far beyond my powers to delineate what the essential differences are; only reflection on the plays themselves can suggest an answer. But, crudely speaking, one can say that the Romans lacked two things possessed by the

Englishmen—a single ruler and a single god. The Romans were neither monarchists nor Christians, but republicans and pagans. This has corresponding effects on the individual Romans. They were solely of this world, and their motivations were almost totally political or erotic. Some believed in gods, but those gods had to do only with political success or failure and did not give indications of a new transcendent dimension to life beyond that provided by civil society. The heroes were unabashedly ambitious of glory; their attention was not distracted by other charms or myths. They were an extraordinary number of able men, none recognizing a master, each honed to a superb edge of emulation.

In *Julius Caesar*, Shakespeare has chosen to depict the greatest of these great men. Paradoxically, it is the greatest Roman of them all who destroyed the Republic which was the seed bed of great Romans. Out of the constant and all-absorbing competition for the rewards of citizenship, finally emerged a victor who could subdue all of his opponents. This was the decisive moment in Roman history, the culmination of the Republic and the threshold of the Empire. The end once achieved, there was nothing left to be done. *Antony and Cleopatra* reveals this. Octavius merely inherits the name of Caesar and thereby inherits the fruits of Caesar's accomplishments. And Octavius is no hero; he is a dry opportunist with the capacity for neither loving nor fighting. Julius Caesar has so skillfully done his work that nothing of the old world can work within the new. It is Antony, in all his decadence, who is the last hero. The elements of the heroic have gone out of balance in him; his spiritedness and his *eros* go in different directions. But to what heights each of these contradictory impulses carry him! He is alive; the force and range of his character win us; and we are unable to resist a sense of bitterness at his inevitable defeat before the humanly inferior Octavius. The heart has gone out of the world, and the unheroic subject will take over from the citizen.

Julius Caesar has prepared the way for monarchy and peace; within that peace can be sown the seeds of a new faith which exalts peace. The old gods leave with the last warrior.³ The old order and its characteristic man must pass before the new one can grow. Caesar is the peak and the end of that old order. Republican Rome had existed and flourished on two conditions—external warfare and domestic faction. Caesar, in principle, ended both of these conditions, which are undesirable in themselves; in so doing, he rendered it no longer necessary to have Romans.

The important question is, then, what were Caesar's talents and what was the policy that brought about such results? As a preliminary step toward answering this question, we must look to the character of the Roman polity as delineated in the plays, for the heroes are faced with Roman problems. They understand themselves to be acting as Roman citizens; what they must be and do is determined by the laws of Rome.

The first thing we learn from both *Coriolanus* and *Julius Caesar* is that Rome is not one city, but two—the city of the rich and the city of the poor. These two cities form an alliance with a shifting balance of power; and it is in relation to this balance that the statesmen play their roles, set their courses, and show what they can do. There is no higher principle or interest that unites them; each is necessary to the other, but they are hostile to each other; and each moderates the goals of the other by sheer force. The city of the rich contains all that is noble and interesting; these are the men who make up the Senate and lead the wars. They are the soul of Rome. Shakespeare is no democrat. It is not, as we shall see, that he

lacks sympathy for the poor; it is rather that he is convinced that certain important virtues can be possessed by only a few and that those few require special training and long tradition. It is this concentration on virtue, and particularly certain political virtues, that leads him to emphasize the special rights of the patricians. If political rights were to be equalized, as happened under Augustus, the virtues of the few would have no field of action. Rome is great by its senatorial class, and that class is really unique— a relatively large group of men who are sufficiently obedient to the laws to avoid both anarchy and the rule of a single man; who sacrifice ordinary weakness and self-indulgence to a strict military discipline, the rewards of which are only honors; and who alone can be trusted to conclude on the issues of war and peace. And this is not for a day, but has endured for hundreds of years. Among them, it seems possible for single individuals to work wonders; Roman history is not the history of huge, impersonal movements, but that of great individuals. The poor, the body of the nation, are tied to their physical needs; their visions are limited by necessity. They possess none of the qualities of statesmanship and are easily led and misled. They change their convictions on the slightest occasions; they are governed by fear; and, when they take on the airs of courage and wisdom, they are revealed to be slavish as soon as they are put to the test. This does not mean that Shakespeare hates them; he knows them to be, like most humans, largely weak, but not vicious. But one must face the facts, and, according to Shakespeare, the man who has greater qualities should be preferred to those who have lesser ones.

Coriolanus failed because he could not handle the people; Caesar succeeded because he betrayed his own class and won the people by appealing to what is basest in them. This is the hidden theme of the Roman plays—the corruption of the people is the key to the mastery of Rome.

The people, under the Republic, really do control the city. They are free and participate in the election of magistrates, although they cannot themselves become magistrates. They possess a power of veto. The constitutional intention of their participation is obviously to prevent the rulers from following policies destructive of the people's interest. The people must be taken account of and not become slaves. This works perfectly as long as the senatorial class is unified and chooses its candidates for office on the basis of what they understand to be necessary for the city as a whole. In this case, the people's power only serves to ensure that a truly common good be found. But, as soon as a group of senators becomes corrupt and wishes to rule in ways and with powers contrary to the sense of the laws, they can appeal over the heads of their equals to the wishes of the people. The people cannot lead, but, as soon as a man who is powerful in the senatorial class can lead them, all is lost. Then the interests of the tyrant and the people rule in opposition to the class that represents virtue.

Both **Coriolanus** and **Julius Caesar** begin with the people, and in both cases they are understood to be the cause of the prevailing unrest. But the body of plebs is quite different in the two plays.⁴ In **Coriolanus**, they are much more solid; the agitation arises because they are oppressed and hungry. Their demands are at least plausible, and they are largely motivated by fear that they will lose what little voice they have. They have just been conceded the establishment of tribunes to express their grievances to an indifferent Senate. They are not paragons, but seem to be ordinary rustic folk; they may not have been good warriors, but they had fought. There is every indication that their claims are legitimate and

that Shakespeare has taken his cue from Plutarch, who insists that lack of consideration for the people was pushed to the point of a vice in **Coriolanus**.⁵ In **Julius Caesar**, on the other hand, there is a lazy, brutal populace, a real urban proletariat. They are accustomed to dominating, and they are insolent; they have the habit of being flattered. How different were those plebs who feared that they were being made fun of by Coriolanus from these, who are the imperious arbiters of the civil war to whom the whole rhetoric of the conspiracy is directed. They are accustomed to bread and circuses; they change heroes according to how much is done for them. In **Coriolanus**, they are afraid of oppression; in **Julius Caesar**, they are indifferent to tyranny and are the causes of it. The people, when poor and held in check by the aristocrats, are perfectly decent and deserving of pity; when in control of the state, they are the enemies of republican institutions. The criticism of them implied in **Coriolanus** is that they are impetuous, in **Julius Caesar**, that they are heartless and fickle.⁶ The tribunes in **Coriolanus** are vile self-seekers who mislead an innocent populace; their power depends on the people's hostility toward the senators and the traditional order. In **Julius Caesar**, the tribunes are courageous opponents of Caesar, protecting the people's interests against the people's wishes. The new Caesarean regime comes from members of the patriciate; in the name of the people, this new regime will suppress the power of the tribunes.⁷ The tribunes are even put in the position of defending the traditional role of the senatorial class, so that the constitution can remain intact! This corruption in the character of the people and their relation to the senators is the measure of the distance between Coriolanus' Rome and Caesar's Rome.

Caesar holds the senators, his peers, in bondage owing to his control of the mob. Throughout the play, it is manifest that the cause of the senators is lost. They cannot unite among themselves, since any union would be quickly broken by those attracted to playing the demagogue and using the strength of the people to gain personal ascendancy. There is no hope of relying on the decency or patriotism of the plebs, for they are blind and corrupt beyond recall. They are incapable of distinguishing their flatterer from the good ruler. The only way to suppress Caesar would be to establish another tyranny. But why do that? The only dignity in the conspiracy comes from its insistence on freedom and legality. Another tyrant would probably be worse than Caesar.

This impasse is most beautifully brought out in the two funeral orations. Brutus speaks as a gentleman addressing gentlemen. His speech is in prose, and he appeals coldly, with no reference to reward, to the civic virtues of his audience. He treats them as old Romans; virtue is its own reward, and his listeners are presumed to possess an unselfish love of liberty. Antony's speech is in verse; he is a rhetorician. The more corrupt the audience, the more brilliant the rhetoric. A good citizen speaks the truth and respects his audience enough to believe they are competent to recognize the common good and virtuous enough to act in accordance with it. The flatterer assumes the baseness of his audience and appeals to its vices, cloaking his enticements in the beauty of his words. Brutus is austere; Antony, charming. And Antony's appeal is based solely on Caesar's benefactions to the people. Caesar could not be a criminal, for he loved the people; that is the sum of Antony's argument. When he gives promise of future reward of the grossest kind, his cause is won. All this he learned in the school of Caesar; Caesar knew how to use the people against the aristocrats, and that was the basis for ending all faction in the name of Caesarism. This play shows the last gasps of senatorial power or the coming-to-consciousness on the part of the

old rulers that their day is done. Their edicts can no longer be enforced; they can either die or learn to live in comfortable obscurity.

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In order to come to grips with Caesar's character, it is well to cast a glance at his opposite number, Coriolanus. The light cast by Coriolanus' failure will illuminate Caesar's success. Coriolanus' greatness is of a sort that turned him from the best of citizens into a traitor condemned by his country; Caesar's greatness turns him from a traitor into the city's god.

Coriolanus' principle makes it impossible for him to deal with the people. It is a matter of simple pride. He is a gentleman, and gentlemen do not debase themselves in order to gain what they desire. Coriolanus, as a result of his public services, deserves to rule; hence, he should be given office without having to seek it or having to add to his sufficient title extraneous adornments that would please an unwise mob.⁸ In all reason, if he is deserving, his refusal to flatter is justified. A decent city rewards decent men. If one must do what is base to gain honor, then the laws, with their noble precepts, would not be the guides to happiness or success; they would not be respectable. Put in another way, the laws or the way of life of a city are products of that group which is dominant in it. The good citizen is the man who best fits this regnant spirit. The virtues Coriolanus possesses fit the spirit of the senatorial class; if this class is the city, he is at home.⁹ If the city is the people or some combination of plebs and patricians, he must moderate or alter his heroic character in order to fit and be honored. Coriolanus wants his kind of man to be dominant in the city; in this, at least, he does not differ from Socrates. What is the good of serving that which is not noble and will not permit him to remain noble? As a consequence of this opinion, he is required to deny the political existence of the great mass of the people.

In a way, Coriolanus' objections to the people are based merely on a prediction that, once admitted to a share in power, the ultimate results will be those we see in **Julius Caesar**. In reading his great diatribes against the people, one cannot help but be impressed with the reasonableness of the substance, if not of the style.¹⁰ All of the accusations are accurate descriptions of the actions and thoughts of the people as Shakespeare describes them. But there is a difference in tone, if one can compare Shakespeare's presentation to that of Coriolanus. The latter is full of hatred and bitterness; there is almost what one would today call a reformer's spirit in Coriolanus' approach. Shakespeare indicates that he himself possesses a spirit of acceptance. That is the way things are, and there is no hope of reforming humanity. In this, Shakespeare, I believe, takes his cue from Plutarch. Plutarch blames Coriolanus, not for his opinion of the people, but for caring about them. He brings in as witness the gentle Aristides, who largely shared Coriolanus' estimation of the many, but who, for that very reason, expected nothing of them. He accepted with the same equanimity the archonship and ostracism. The difference between the two men is that Coriolanus is hungry for honor;¹¹ that is his deepest urge. He wishes to prove himself best. A man only knows himself best on the witness of others; he, as a Roman, must follow the **cursus honorum**, success in which is the sign of virtue.

However, this success now depends on the people, who vote according to their understanding and taste. To be attached to them is contemptible; they are not worthy judges. There is a myth that the man who obeys the laws and is courageous in war will be rewarded;

actually, the man who is best adapted to the popular temper of his nation is the one who succeeds. Coriolanus' spirited nobility will not permit him to accept this fact. If easy deception is the road to honor, why should he engage in the difficult enterprises that made him famous? He wants competent judges of his merit; he wants Aufidius to be great so that he can defeat him;¹² he needs a world of heroes to fight so that he can be approved the hero among heroes. He does not want to win a cheating election that covers the true qualities of things; he wants others to admire him for what he really is. Coriolanus wants his virtue to be independent. But, in the decisive sense, he is dependent on the city, which is not virtuous, but is a composite of good and bad. All the honor that comes from it is tainted. This is Coriolanus' tragedy.

Coriolanus, extrapolating from the principles of a gentleman, in reality wants his virtue and honor to be those of a god. Gods are worshiped because they are powerful and good, not because they flatter the city. What they do for men they do freely and as a result of prayers; they are not needy. When Coriolanus is finally forced to the choice between a compromise and revolting against civil authority, he chooses the latter course. He believes that he can punish Rome for its ingratitude.¹³ He takes on a horrible grandeur in his anger and is like a raging, merciless god—"He wants nothing of a god but eternity and a heaven to throne in."¹⁴ But this moment is short-lived. Coriolanus without a political role is no Coriolanus, and, to live a political life, one must have a city to lead and to rule. Coriolanus no longer has a city. He can never return to Rome, because he hates it and because he would never again be trusted. And the city he thinks he is using for his revenge is in reality only using him; he has no place in it.¹⁵

All this is brought home to him when his mother comes to plead—this terrible woman who nurtured him to his pride. He loves her and pities her; she cannot live without the approval of Rome. Volumnia had never dreamed it possible that there could be a conflict between raising a proud, insigent Roman and being a good citizen. She chooses the city when confronted with the choice between it and her son. Coriolanus' remaining contact with human sentiments is through his mother, and it is this weakness that destroys him. A god has no pity, because he is too far above the pains of humans to be threatened by them. His purpose cannot be altered by pleas; at least he cannot be forced to change. Coriolanus' attachment to his mother forces him to behave as a citizen. After all, Coriolanus was like other men, and he should not have aspired to rise so high.

Aristotle says that a man without a city is a god or a beast. Coriolanus, who made the attempt to live without a city, at first appears to be a god and proves to be a beast, slain in ambush like one.¹⁶ He had no real source of power or humanity outside of Rome. The lesson to be drawn for our purposes is that a man cannot become a god, in Rome at least, on the patrician principles. The people's love is necessary; a god unworshiped is no god. The people's love is not won by mere heroic virtue. In other words, a man who wishes to become a god, who is conscious of the extent of his ambition, cannot behave as gods are popularly understood to behave. The base tribunes who fear that Coriolanus will become a god are able to prevent it; the noble tribunes and conspirators, in trying to forestall Caesar's becoming a god, are themselves destroyed.

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Caesar had learned this well. He performed deeds as least as great as those of Coriolanus, but they were only steps on the road to the fulfillment of his dreams. Caesar's victories were used to subvert the constitution and get a hold on the people. He combined military force, to hold the Republic, with great generosity, to gain the love of the people. He knew that mere generosity or good deeds in the past would not suffice. The people had forgotten Pompey. But this union of force with courting of the people rendered the Senate completely impotent. No rival could muster enough of a following to challenge him. Caesar's control of the city of Rome, with all its prestige, was decisive in the civil war. This policy was doubly strong because, with the people as an ally, he had no rivals among them to fear. The people are easily satisfied; only patricians, who live for the freedom and influence guaranteed to their position by the constitution, feel the consequences of having a single ruler.

All this is subtle policy, but it comes from the soul of a man who is no gentleman; it is a policy of ruse, treachery, violence, and treason. All canons of loyalty and decency go by the board; virtue is only a means to the end of glory and is hence only accessory. What is remarkable is that this man, who cares so little for the conventional virtues, does not degenerate into mere self-indulgence, that he possesses the charms of nobility.

Caesar was ready to undergo every kind of degradation; he knew that he was in need of other men, men not gained by virtue. Coriolanus could understand himself as a man devoted to the common good; Caesar's selfishness is explicit. This is, of course, an old story, and it is far easier to espouse such a Caesarean policy than to pursue it. It only goes to show that Caesar's greatness had as its condition a neglect of ordinary legality and decency. Although the people praise the practice of the virtues, in deed they consider the good man to be the one who benefits and attribute all the virtues to him. This Caesar knew, and his genius was guided by this awareness. The man who tried to be faithful to the traditions of Rome and the highest principles of morality was inevitably a traitor to Rome; the man who broke every sacred law and cared not a whit for the simplest principles of faith became a god. The paradox of Caesar's character—a character capable of the highest ambition and the lowest deeds—is formulated by Montesquieu in Machiavellian fashion: "This extraordinary man had . . . many great qualities without a single defect, although he had many vices. . . ." 17

Caesar's roots in the acclaim of the worst sort of citizen is the first stage in Shakespeare's ambiguous presentation of him. Caesar is a man who has built his palace on the ruins of the Republic. Of course, there is every indication that it was already very corrupt. But the man who takes advantage of corruption is not particularly admirable, and one who destroys the manly equality of trusting friends and so gains his glory is a questionable figure.¹⁸ Caesar is not like Romulus, who did disagreeable things in order to found the greatest of all republics. Whether Caesar intended to found anything is not clear, and what he did in fact found was distinctly inferior to what preceded.

On the other hand, to have overcome such rivals and to have found a formula that, in restoring peace between plebs and patricians, at the same time exalted himself, argues that he possessed no mean qualities. Even if they do not evoke respect, they do at least evoke wonder. It is often said that Caesar is a mere tyrant, and the play is understood to be a panegyric to the republican spirit and to tyrannicide.¹⁹ This view, however, requires a selective reading of Caesar's interventions and forgets the obvious fact that the conspiracy

ultimately fails. This failure is not just bad luck; it has to do with Caesar's strengths and Brutus' and Cassius' weaknesses. After all, the play ends with the punishment of the murderers and the triumph of the Caesarean party.

This in no sense implies that the interpretation which takes the conspiracy to be simply wicked is correct. But at least it begins from the broad lines presented by the play itself. The issue cannot be avoided by asserting that Shakespeare was only interested in the depiction of character and that the justice of the cause does not play a role in his thinking or in his play. Justice is part of a man's character, and Shakespeare knew it. One might suggest that the play takes for granted that there was something superior in the old Rome and that tyranny is a bad thing, but that Caesar's tyranny was something unique and that this was not properly grasped by the conspirators. Perhaps this individual, although inimical to constitutional and hence healthy regimes, is so superior that he deserves to rule no matter what. Perhaps our sympathies should be divided between respect for legitimacy and astonishment at Caesar's talents. Nothing says that there must be a harmony between civic morality and human greatness, and perhaps there was no alternative at that time and place. Then we would be forced to admire Caesar's political skill while honoring the dead—but always renewable—republican principles of the conspirators. It is this series of "perhaps's" that is the source of the obscurity of Shakespeare's intention.

It is possible to play Caesar as a petty, petulant, frightened despot, but it would be absurd to do so. There would then be no accounting for how Caesar had got where he is or for the general opinion that he was "the noblest man that ever lived in the tide of time."²⁰ I say that this opinion is general, although I quote from the mouth of Antony. Brutus has a similar esteem for him, and even those who hate Caesar never speak of him as anything but an exceptional individual. Cassius' tirade against him, with all its venom and rhetorical inflation, never describes Caesar as a minor man. Cassius simply insists that he is a man and that the differences in men cannot be so great as to allow one to rule all others, at least when there are Cassius's and Brutus's around.²¹ The high point of his argument is that Brutus could conceive of himself as equal to Caesar. In the judgments of his contemporaries, Caesar is a very important personage, and not important in the sense in which a hereditary monarch is important. The latter must be reckoned with, not because of what he has himself accomplished, but merely because of the force of tradition, whereas Caesar has made his own situation and has the force to strengthen it.

Nor is he a tyrant in the sense of those who want the first position in order to indulge private lusts and for whom political power is merely a means of being free of the ordinary civil restrictions. Caesar's ambition is allied to a certain kind of public spirit; he wishes Rome to be happy and healthy under his leadership. Although his power is in the people, he respects the patricians and wants them to be his friends. He is still, in one way, the traditional Roman; he wants to win his glory from the free assent of the members of his class. He has made efforts to win them and has not merely purged all men of spirit, after the fashion of the tyrant. Brutus, a former opponent, stands high in his councils, and the dangerous Cassius is left undisturbed. The exquisite urbanity we know in the historical Caesar is to be found here, too.²² We see examples of Caesar's astuteness and his high-minded lack of concern for his safety.²³ Much of the complaint against him stems from pique, vanity, and envy. Although some of his speeches smack to us of bombast, it is not so clear that this was Shakespeare's intention, for ours is not an age that takes well to speech of the heroic variety. There is a

certain distance in manner and a pride in expression necessary to the leader, especially the leader in civil strife.

So much for the more extreme charges against Shakespeare's Caesar.²⁴ But there is also no question that there is a certain disproportion between Caesar's rhetoric about himself and what little we see of him in action. He says that he is not touched by fear; but he gives way, if not to his own fears, at least to those of his wife. And he delivers his marvelous speech about being unmovable just after we have seen him moved by flattery.²⁵ Finally, in desiring a crown and the title of king, he seems guilty of imprudence. The people, who are serving under a monarch, do not wish to be aware of a situation which they themselves have created. Names mean everything to the people, and substance, nothing. Caesar appears to affront this sentiment unnecessarily, since he already holds all the real power of a king. There is something petty in his desire, however logical a consequence it may be of his own ambitions. It is the cause of the conspirators' final resolution.²⁶

It might be suggested that the real, live Caesar who confronts us is a man at the end of his career. He has accomplished all he has to do. There are few great actions left; he has only to reap vain honors. He has triumphed over all possible opponents, and with a certain sadness sees that his equals are no longer his equals. Pompey is dead, and there is no Aufidius, for all the Volscians have been conquered. In spite of his moderation and generosity, he cannot trust those around him. There is no way to distinguish true love from the blandishments of the frightened and interested; he does control by arms, not love. He lives only on words, his own and others. One can hardly imagine that such a man could settle down to the career of a peaceful public administrator. All that remains is the last forbidden fruit, the crown, the opposition to which was the vital center of the Republic's history. We see the glowing ashes of a Caesar who has been consumed in his passion for glory. He is now indecisive and prone to error. What is left is his own vision of what he wanted to be and how he should be understood by others.²⁷

Caesar conceives of himself as a god. Unlike mortals, his will is not determined by reason; his will is sufficient reason.²⁸ This is the sign of omnipotence. In his last speech, when he is closest to the apprehension of mortality, he compares himself to the immortals. Among his last words before the attack are, "Wilt thou move Olympus." ²⁹ Then he disappears forever. One might think that this was the clearest proof of Caesar's pride and the fitting punishment for it. But, in reality, the conspirators have made him into a god. They have saved him from the errors of humanity and its weaknesses. The position he had created was too great to be filled by a man, even Caesar; but Caesar's spirit, once released from his body, ranged over the wide world. The conspirators prevented Caesar from making the final error of allowing himself to be called king. Instead, they made it possible for kings to be honored to be called "Caesar."

Caesar's name became identical with monarchy of the grandest kind. His own person would not have sufficed to this role; but the edifice carefully constructed by him plus the memory of his martyrdom formed an almost eternal imperium. If the republican conspirators had not slain him, he might well have gained the odium of most Romans, as is indicated by the people's initial reaction to the tendering of the crown. The conspiracy saved Caesar from himself. From the moment the daggers are withdrawn from the corpse, Caesar's spirit comes alive to dominate the rest of the play's action. ³⁰

****IV****

Caesar required honor upon honor in order to live; universal empire was the fulfillment of his ambitions. Only the situation of a god could satisfy his thirst, and he did achieve this satisfaction—eternal fame and worship. 31 But, humanly, he wanted the free and honest admiration of the best men of his time, and this he did not get. As a man, he was a failure; his tragedy is consummated in seeing the Roman senators—and particularly the most virtuous of them all, Brutus—he had so sedulously courted attack him. To be Caesar is no solution to the problem of leading a noble political life that is not tragic, not rooted in fundamental contradictions. But no political man is his equal.

It is in the analysis of this alliance of senators that Shakespeare teaches the tragedy of Caesar and of Rome. It was formed to put an end to Caesar's endless ambition and restore a Rome in which men had ruled and been ruled by one another in turn, a Rome in which the pride of equality among equals and submission to the laws was the theme and where individual deeds had unlimited possibilities and an exalted significance. The alliance failed, and this failure is due, on the one hand, to the skill of Caesar's work and, on the other hand, to the inadequacies of the conspirators. We are shown the hearts and the minds of the conspirators, and we become aware of the awesome talents that would have been required to make the conspiracy succeed and what the imperfections were that doomed it. Shakespeare telescopes history so as to draw out its true significance, and he leaves nothing to accident. The actors and their faults are everything; material circumstances and chance are reduced to an almost meaningless minimum.

The conspiracy has two leaders, and they are responsible for the execution of the plot. Shakespeare has centered the whole action around them and has done so to an even greater degree than did his source, Plutarch. They act in the name of all Rome, in particular in the name of the senatorial class. Casca is given as the model of the decent, blunt, independent men who are typical of that class. Those who follow are the Casca's, but what they follow is the product of Brutus and Cassius. These two are special types who differ extremely and whose capacities complement each other but also bring them into crucial conflict. Brutus and Cassius are necessarily mated, for, without either one, it is inconceivable that the conspiracy should have begun at all. They are, however, too diverse to work together in complete harmony; their principles produce different policies. They would have to have been in complete concord to succeed; but that is very like an impossibility, because nature has made them so opposite. The plot should have been led by one man who had the qualities of both Brutus and Cassius. But how could nature have made such a monster? The sign of this natural impossibility is that one is a self-announced Stoic and the other a self-proclaimed Epicurean—the two opposite poles in philosophical sectarianism. Could a man be both Stoic and Epicurean?

The motivations of both Brutus and Cassius are truly republican, with the difference that, according to the formula of the time, the one hated tyranny, and the other, tyrants.³² Brutus believed in legitimacy, in the traditional Roman order. Cassius could not endure having to accept a master. Both positions reflect elements in the republican character; the one represents the principles, the other, the passions which must be combined for a republican regime to endure. Brutus' reasons for participation seem more public-spirited and better

grounded in virtue. Cassius is apparently pursuing a private grudge, but his response to his private passion is a strong and free one. Both Brutus and Cassius are noble Romans, the sort of men who made republican Rome the glory of political history.

Cassius is the animator of the plot. He has the idea, and he organizes everything. Conspiracies are low things; they require secrecy and stealth. As such, they are not the best ground for gentlemen, who are not in the habit of hiding anything or of feeling the shame that seeks the cover of darkness. This does not bother Cassius.³³ Caesar is a tyrant; there are no lawful means to do justice to a tyrant who has usurped all lawfulness. Therefore, he must be done away with. His view of the end dictates the means, and he moves clear-headedly toward the goal without conscience. Cassius needs no painful dialectic with himself to prove that it is right for gentlemen to commit murder. He is much more sanguinary than his colleague, and his colleague has only become his colleague because he has been subtly corrupted by Cassius. It is also not the office of a gentleman to deceive a man who is supposed to be his friend. But Cassius wants Brutus in on the assassination, so he feels no compunction about presenting him with images which will appeal to his ambition, an ambition so pure that its highest object is to gain the reputation for virtue.³⁴ Why does the able and courageous Cassius want to associate himself with the pure Brutus? The answer is that Cassius needs Brutus, for Brutus has the reputation for virtue which will draw other worthy men into the conspiracy, and, after the assassination, only he could make the deed appear to the people to be good and just.³⁵ Virtue is necessary to political success; it is a weapon. The reputation for honor and justice is not gained in a day; Cassius may be a clever statesman, but his very cleverness has made it impossible for him to acquire the reputation for virtue. This conspiracy needs a reputation which can equal Caesar's, as well as a prudence to match his. Cassius needs Brutus for the sake of public opinion.

Brutus is a man who loves virtue, who only asks himself what the right thing to be done is. He does not, like Cassius, calculate what advantage will accrue to him if he behaves rightly. He is not a regular fellow; he seems cold; but he is the sort of man to whom others turn in cases where trust is important. He demands much of others, but also of himself. He applies the strictest rules of justice and does not mitigate them out of friendship or pity. Brutus is truly a Stoic. For that reason, since reputation is so important in political things, less just men are tempted to try to use him as a front to mask their schemes or to give an air of respectability to their selfish motives. Caesar prized his friendship, and Cassius tries to seduce him.

In addition to being a virtuous man, Brutus is also eminently a political animal. He is no less political than Cassius, who sees all happiness and joy in exercising the rights of a Roman citizen. Brutus understands virtuous conduct to be that of a wise and sober counselor and judge. Just as Cassius, from the point of view of his philosophy, could have chosen a life of voluptuary satisfaction and turned his back on political honors, so Brutus, too, from the point of view of his philosophy, could have chosen the life of the solitary sage who studies nature indifferent to the passing currents of political life. But he did not become a sage because virtue, to him, is incorporated in the life of the good citizen. He despises honor; he is apparently insensitive to what moves Caesar and Cassius. However, he can hardly be imagined outside the role of statesman and general; without the occasion for the exercise of those activities, Brutus could not be virtuous and hence happy. It is a mistake to say that Brutus is a theoretical man not made for political practice. Undoubtedly, his notion of the

virtues makes it difficult for him to act prudently in extreme situations, but that does not mean that this notion is not fundamentally political or that Brutus can live in any other world than that of the city and its dispensing of justice. He apparently has shown himself competent in a life devoted entirely to politics. The fact that he reads books does not prove that there is anything philo- sophic in him; it might only indicate that he is somewhat bookish. He, as much as the other characters in the play, has the passion for politics coursing through his veins.

Brutus brings respectability, calm, and resolve to the conspiracy. Nobody can question this; since he is not afraid of consequences, once he has made up his mind, he is unshakable. Cassius has doubts and terrors and sometimes is disposed to act rashly.³⁶ With Brutus, the only difficulty is in deciding to do the deed. But this is not easy. His Stoic calm disposes him to accept the evils of the time. He is, above all men, indebted to Caesar. Finally, murder is contrary to his principles. In his reflections on the problem, we see his characteristic mode of reasoning and penetrate the difficulties of the moral stance which ultimately makes him so disastrous a partner in crime. He reasons in terms of how the killing of Caesar can be justified to the public, how it will receive the "color" of morality.³⁷ Brutus is determined on action because the deed is one that can be justified in terms of the public understanding of virtue. For Cassius, it is sufficient to hate serving another human being; the Stoic Brutus could never accept the judgment of the selfish passions; rather, one should change those passions. Only reasons will do. But what are sufficient reasons? It seems that they are those which can satisfy the public at large. Brutus will not act out of self-love; he prides himself on acting contrary to the movements of his heart. But he will act according to the popular view of what is decent, not because he hopes to be popular, but because he has no other source of knowledge about what is decent.

Brutus' situation can be characterized in this way: he believes that to be virtuous is to be happy. If one obeys the laws of virtue without fail, it makes no difference whether one has any of the external goods. But what is virtue? In answer to this question, he can only respond: what is held to be virtuous. He is so completely a political man that he cannot conceive of a virtuous life which is not the life of a Roman senator. But this means that virtue is not really a completely individual possession; one must belong to a city. Brutus' virtue is not an unknown or private virtue, like that of the most authentic Stoics, who took Diogenes as one of their supreme models. Brutus, as we learn, really admits that happiness requires conditions in addition to virtue. He believes that one must have a city in which to exercise virtue, or, otherwise put, one must have some political honor. A city draws its moral principles from its laws, and the laws and their spirit are what Brutus truly listens to. But what never seems to occur to him is that, on occasion, those laws need forbidden, unlawful actions for their maintenance. Caesar and Cassius are only too aware of this fact; injustice may be the condition of justice or happiness. It is only too clear why Brutus does not consider this possibility: if there are no permanent principles of justice, if virtue requires supplements which are not virtuous, if to be a good man and a happy one are at least potentially different things, then how would one choose between them? Brutus' calm superiority to base considerations and his freedom from anxiety about the conditions of happiness rest on the conviction that morality is absolute.

The murder of Caesar is, of course, a great break with the absoluteness of Brutus' principles, and it is only after a struggle with himself that he brings himself to undertake it. It is doubtful

whether he ever really permits himself full consciousness of what he has done. In reality, he tries to convert the deed into something other than what it is. He understands it to be a sacrifice to the gods, the sources of morality.³⁸ Even if he does see that this is an extraordinary, extramoral deed, he is unwilling to draw the obvious consequence. This consequence is that, once one has performed such a deed, one must do all that is necessary to make it effective; the old rules do not apply, since one is already outside the rules. Instead, Brutus reverts immediately to his stringent principles and lets the consequences be damned, even though Caesar has been killed for the consequences which might follow from his power. Brutus assumes that Romans will behave morally, although Caesar has won his position by corrupting them. It is Brutus' unwillingness to embark on a stormy political sea without a moral compass that leads him to make several errors. These errors are all committed over Cassius' opposition. Shakespeare has contrasted the two men with almost geometric precision in each case, and the failure of the plot can be directly traced to the victory of Brutus' principles over Cassius' prudence.

Brutus refuses to admit Cicero into the plot; he refuses to kill Antony; he insists that Antony be permitted to speak at Caesar's funeral; he opts to do battle immediately, rather than delay.³⁹ Cassius wanted to do otherwise in each question. In two of the cases, Cassius was the initiator of the contrary policy and was overridden by Brutus. In two instances, public opinion is alleged as the motive for disagreeing with Cassius; in the third, fortune and its effects on human policy is the reason;⁴⁰ and, in the fourth, Brutus alleges that Cicero's vanity makes it impossible for him to be a follower, which means, since Brutus is the acknowledged leader, that he wants no challenge to his leadership. Although a plausible and moral ground can be made for each of Brutus' decisions, each can be referred to the more ambiguous sides of his character—the moral self-confidence and the urge for public respectability. He pays scant attention to Cassius, of whose qualities he is less aware than Cassius is of his. Cassius always gives in, almost without discussion. It might be a cause of wonder why he does so, since he is so conscious of his own intellectual clarity. The answer is Brutus' moral superiority. Cassius cannot hope to prevail in an open conflict, for the others would follow Brutus without question. They trust him. More important, Cassius' lack of principle gives him a certain lack of will. The conviction of one's own virtue is a source of strength. Brutus believes that he is self-sufficient, whereas Cassius is only too aware of his own dependence. Morality is a real force, and Cassius is intimidated by it.

Let us now look at the errors themselves more closely. No proof is required to assert that it was an act of gross conspiratorial stupidity to leave Mark Antony alive. The denouement is enough for that. Mark Antony was the heir to Caesar's teaching and could certainly not be trusted. Similarly, the funeral oration was the means to arouse the people, the source of Caesar's power. In one way, Brutus' gentleness can be regarded as a virtue; he was too good for this world. He wanted to do away with the evil without making the cure worse than the disease. Cassius' policy would have led to bloody purges. Looked at in another way, Brutus is culpably weak, given the importance of the issue at stake; gentleness can be seen as a kind of self-indulgence. At all events, by saving Antony, Brutus saved Caesar. Further, Brutus' precipitousness to begin the battle is clearly mistaken. Appian's assertion that the argument presented by Cassius is correct is not even necessary; Octavius himself says that what Brutus does is precisely the thing their party wants.⁴¹

Finally, although it is less easy to detect the error involved in the rejection of Cicero, I believe that Shakespeare's presentation of the great orator is such as to indicate that his taking part would have been a decisive asset. We learn from hearsay that Cicero is a subtle man who knows how to mask his sentiments and that he, like Brutus, would add respectability to the conspiracy, although he is regarded for his judgment, rather than for his nobility. The one glimpse we get of him is most revealing. Casca meets him in the midst of the great storm which seems to give cosmic support to the unrest within Rome. Casca is struck with awe; he is a moral man and a superstitious one. The gods, the guardians of morality, are sending signs. Cicero is calm and unmoved and implies that he does not believe that these storms have anything to do with human affairs. He remains reasonable, whereas the religious Casca gives himself over to tormented speculations. Casca then meets Cassius, who is also a non-believer, but whom the storm has stimulated to wild impiety and defiance of the heavens. He uses the events to intensify the hostility to Caesar. Cicero is a golden mean in the scene between the terrified believer and the fanatic unbeliever. He is not a man to see ghosts, nor is he one who has renounced morality. Perhaps he could have mediated between Brutus' moral passion and Cassius' calculation.

Given that Cicero might have possessed talents deserving of a place in the plot, what would have been the result of his participation? Whether he would have been the leader or not, it is hardly to be believed that the man universally acknowledged the greatest orator in Roman history would not have presented the reasons for the assassination at Caesar's funeral. Brutus' speech was a failure and wrongly conceived, and we know, and Shakespeare could have known, that the real Cicero disapproved of Brutus' rhetoric. Would Cicero have so widely missed the mark? I doubt it.⁴²

A single thread can be seen running through all Brutus' errors. It comes best into view in his objections to doing away with Antony. Antony is only Caesar's limb; all one needs to do is kill Caesar's spirit, and the body will die. Brutus wishes that he could kill Caesar's spirit without touching his body. But we have learned that Caesar's spirit is very much in the body and inseparable from it. Indeed, it can be said that his spirit lives in that part of the city which is most body. Caesar more than anyone knew that the soul must have material manifestations in order to have political significance; a great spirit must produce courageous armies and quantities of money. In a way, Brutus knows this, but his doctrine makes him forget it. He does not believe in the importance of external goods; strength of soul is all that counts. This is a salutary and inspiring doctrine, but it is not true. Caesar's spirit lives on in his arms. Brutus systematically underrates the importance of what is lowest—the body. Cassius vainly tells him that their opponents will starve if given time. But for Brutus "there is a tide in the affairs of men which taken at the flood leads on to success . . ."; he believes that his spirit and resolve will carry all before them.

His rejection of Cicero and his granting permission to Antony to speak reveal the same bias in an even deeper sense. Rhetoric is not important; honest men speak the truth to one another without ornament. A depreciation of rhetoric is a depreciation of the importance of the passions and of the distortions they effect on reason. He who knows rhetoric knows the people, and the people are the body of the state. Cassius, the materialist, the Epicurean, tries vainly to point this out to Brutus. It is true that Cassius thinks that everything is body, and he therefore misses something Brutus sees. But he is closer to an understanding of the

extremities of politics than is the stoic Brutus, with his unshakable conviction that the soul's virtues are sufficient in themselves, not only for the wise man but for cities as well.

Up to this point, Brutus' faults, if they can be called such, are so bound up with all his good qualities that they possess a certain charm and might incline one to believe that there is only a choice between sweet but somewhat blind virtue and malignant prudence. In this light, Brutus would be vindicated. However, these failings take on a somewhat more somber cast in the quarrel with Cassius.⁴³

This dispute is the most terrible and most touching moment in the drama. Here these last two hopes of Roman freedom confront one another in a final accounting. Cassius' complaints are just. Brutus has treated him with hauteur. Brutus' moral superiority has become a source of tyranny. He demands of his friend the same perfection he demands of himself. His indignation at Cassius' taking money to pay the troops is based on a higher principle, but it ignores the immediate necessity. Cassius, who has acted from necessity and who is the source of the conspiracy, is made to feel his dependence and his inferiority. Brutus' purity has become cold and self-righteous. Cassius, who has never been able to free himself from the power of Brutus' virtue, breaks down and begs forgiveness. Brutus, too, is human and recognizes the need for friends. He asks forgiveness in turn. The bond between them is restored, but only on the condition that Brutus' will prevails. The two men are no longer equals; Brutus is the master.

The quarrel reveals the deep fissure in the alliance. Cassius has always known that he needs Brutus; Brutus has only now come to realize that he needs Cassius. The superior man has been humbled. Cassius' calculation has been vindicated in practice. The purely moral man has had to descend to the level of ordinary humanity. Brutus has learned that virtue is not sufficient; he must compromise with the necessities of politics. But he has not learned the lesson well enough. The compromise he makes is only a grudging one, and he continues to believe that his moral vision is the only true one. The result is that the alliance is no longer a true partnership; it is a hierarchy. Brutus is the master, and Cassius is the servant. This is not the relation that will produce victory.

The quarrel is the last great scene in the play. From this point on, the conspiracy is doomed. Brutus' errors have made the victory of the Caesarean party inevitable. The final act is only the working out of the consequences of what has already been decided. The ghost of Caesar appears to Brutus and tells him that he will see him at Philippi. The spirit of Caesar dominates the battlefield; the conspirators are defeated. Brutus and Cassius kill themselves. Brutus' last words are a recognition of Caesar's victory: "O Julius Caesar, thou art mighty yet." 44 The play ends with the triumph of the Caesarean party and the praise of Brutus by Antony and Octavius. The republican cause is lost, but Brutus is honored as the noblest Roman of them all.

The conspiracy failed because it was led by men who were not equal to the task. Caesar's genius had created a situation in which only a man of his own stature could undo what he had done. The republican cause required a man who could combine the moral purity of Brutus with the political realism of Cassius. No such man existed. The alliance of the two was the closest approximation, but it was not enough. The very qualities that made each man admirable made it impossible for them to work together in perfect harmony. The tragedy

of the conspiracy is the tragedy of Rome itself—the tragedy of a city that had produced the greatest of men but could not produce a man great enough to save it.

Caesar's victory is complete. His spirit rules Rome. The Republic is dead, and the Empire is born. The age of heroes is over. The new world is one in which peace and order will prevail, but at the cost of the old Roman virtue. The play ends with the praise of Brutus, but it is the praise of a dead man. The future belongs to Caesar.